

Power to the people

Lightly press the power button once to soft-reset and exit to the main menu

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Geek review

movements within games.

The DSi loses the GBA slot of the DS and DS Lite, which makes certain accessories – such as the paddle attachment of Arkanoid DS, the key grip of the Guitar Hero: On Tour game, the RAM pack for the DS Web browser, and the rumble pack – deadweights on the new console. And of course, you can no longer play GameBoy Advance (GBA) games on the DSi. This change makes the unit about 12 per cent thinner than the DS Lite but also slightly longer. The increased length is used to offer larger screens – now at 3.25 inches each, up from the older model's 3-inch screens.

While Nintendo hasn't revealed any spec changes, the DSi is powered by two ARM-based processors – ARM9 and ARM7, with the main processor clocked at 133 MHz. Its internal RAM has been increased four times to 16 MB. It also comes with 256 MB of flash storage, with the possibility of expansion through the SD slot. The DSi supports SDHC, and we successfully tested its operation with a 32 GB SD card.

Manufacturing fun

There are significant software changes made to the OS of the DSi: from the mundane (yet overdue) support of WPA security for wireless access (although older DS titles will not be able to access WPA-compatible routers and access points), to the significant revamp of the entire software interface and introduction of several key programs.

The underlying philosophy for the new software seems to be interactivity and fun (although the latter is subjective). Take the camera app to begin with: you can snap pictures by hitting the left or right shoulder buttons on the

DSi, using either the external camera for friends or family, or the internal camera for self-portraits. Photos can either be stored in internal memory or on the SD card. And then – and this is where the subjective fun aspect lies – you can apply 'filters' to photos. These

filters let you morph photos, or add sparkle, hearts, flowers to a photo, add/remove colours from a photo, compare and juxtapose, draw moustaches, snap on glares... you get the picture. Some might be endlessly entertained by this aspect of snapping and playing; while others bored by merely reading about it here, but the intent is to "have fun with photos in social situations", rather than, "take high-quality photos as mementoes".

A sound app shares the philosophy of interactivity. Here you can record your own voice via the DSi's microphone; you can also 'play' with your personal music collection accessed via the SD slot. Note that the DSi only supports the AAC audio codec. You can play with the pitch and speed of sound files as well as apply filters to sounds which add voice effects such as helium (for that chipmunk effect), transceiver (a radio effect), 8-bit (to hit it old school), and even allows you to play a track backwards. The music player offered is competent enough and offers a decent bunch of visualizations on the top screen, supports playlists, and even lets you join in a song via preset clapping, drumming, or cymbal sounds.

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The DSi introduces an online shop called DSiWare, wherein you are encouraged to spend. To that end, Nintendo even

CAVEAT EMPTOR!

Wii Points and Nintendo DSi points are not interchangeable. If you redeem them at the Wii Shop, you cannot use them at the DSi Shop, and vice-versa

doles out 1000 Nintendo DSi points free with the purchase of a DSi console – a limited time offer, but one made with the philosophy of 'the first one is always free', for sure. This online shop is region-locked and the US version, to which we had

access, offers little to blow money on as of this writing (a total of 15 games plus one free browser). Access to the DSi Shop requires a wireless router or access point and also requires purchase of the aforementioned DSi points (each point is approximately a US cent in value). Software sold here ranges from free to 800+ points. Currently, free gets you an Opera-powered web browser – capable, if not nearly as useful as its Wii counterpart. You can purchase points via the DSi, but you will need an international credit card and a location-specific billing address – if you have a US DSi, you will need US details; if UK, then UK details, and so on. Note that the Japanese unit does not offer an English interface. You could use a web site to purchase said points, as we did using www.maximuscards.com. Purchase through the DSi Store is straightforward, fast, and downloaded software is transferable to an SD card.

Is it worth the upgrade?

If you have a DS Lite, should you upgrade to the DSi? The answer is – it depends. Do you play a lot of GBA titles and do not have a GBA/SP/Micro? If yes, then the DSi will not be a replacement system but will be another console to carry. If the DSi is your first DS system then the answer is an obvious

YES – there are many great titles to own and enjoy on this handheld. Furthermore, the DSi Shop and thus the DSiWare introduced are worthwhile additions. There are already some good games to pick up (see box), and to some these games are reason enough to make the upgrade. There is also the promise of future DSi-enhanced, and DSi-only games. Games that will utilize the additional horsepower and the added cameras – Legend of Zelda: Spirit Tracks (working title) is already rumoured to offer camera functionalities to DSi owners. Note though: you wish to pick up the DSi for its two cameras, then don't. The cameras are nothing great, photos shot take up a green or blue tinge, and their low-light performance is abysmal. Further, there is only one DSiWare game that makes significant use of the cameras (Wario Ware: Snapped) and this too falters more often than not – playing this game is a frustrating exercise in finding just the correct lighting conditions or the game's facial recognition aspects fail.

However, the DSiWare library is the best reason to pick up a DSi. But here DRM rears its ugly head: DSiWare titles are region-locked and you cannot purchase a game sold on a UK store, using a US console. It remains unclear whether DSi-specific retail titles will be locked to regions as well. On that aspect at least, the DSi is unequivocally a step back. Another point to consider is that the DSi costs more than the DS Lite that it replaces – by about \$40.

So what's our verdict? If you love to spend time with Nintendo-style downloadable titles, then you should immediately pick up the DSi, for everyone else we would suggest waiting for the inevitable price drop and DSi-specific retail games.



Real Soccer 2009 (800 points):

Once a retail game, it offers 60 international and 98 club teams from all over Europe. Full touch controls bring gesture based soccer to the DSi. You can also use the camera to snap pictures to paste across the stadium, the ball, and even player's faces. A must-buy for soccer fans.



Art Style AQUIA & Art Style PiCTOBiTs (500 points each):

Two great puzzle games that you must play. Just buy them already.